These were houses whose room floors were either of beaten earth or ‘bajri’ (a coarse sandy aggregate) rammed with mud. Earth also covered the roofs of these houses.

Many of these Taxilan abodes of the third century BCE had been built over earlier habitations going back some two hundred years and more. Instead of removing the remains of collapsed and destroyed roofs, walls, and floors, the common practice seems to have been to level them and build new rooms and courtyards over them. Under Mauryan period houses, facilities that had existed in houses of a greater antiquity have been found simply buried intact. One of the affluent homes, called House K, had a drain under two of its rooms, while in another room two large storage jars lay beneath the floor.[37]

Since the old debris, made up of stones, pottery, and other kinds of rubbish, was unlikely to have been an easy matrix to dig into, residents usually chose to keep the foundations of the new structures relatively shallow. This was an easy enough way of rebuilding. The problem was that it failed to provide the necessary stability to the new structures. Cracks and crumbling plaster must have been quite common, alerting the citizenry to structural weaknesses in their dwellings. To provide additional support, wooden pillars were then erected inside the rooms. Such pillars have not survived but their existence has been surmised from the several shafts (filled with rubble) that have been identified; on these, heavy limestone blocks were placed to provide a firm base for the pillars. One house which required such support was House H, where the roofs of rooms are thus propped up. The remains of a circular pillar stand in the middle of a room, while another room shows the remnants of a square pillar.

The use of English letters as designations—‘House K’, ‘House H’, etc.—can seem odd, but it is common practice when the names and identities of the residents are unknown. Firmer names tend to be given when a building’s resident or purpose is clear. In the ancient town of Bhita near Allahabad,